

It was said that as soon as Warren Buffett was born he was fascinated by numbers. That may be a stretch, but it is well documented that before he entered kindergarten he was already a calculating machine. As young boys, he and his best friend Bob Russell would sit on the Russell family porch recording license-plate numbers of the cars that passed by. When darkness fell, he and Bob would go inside, spread the *Omaha World-Herald* on the floor, and count the number of times each letter appeared in the paper. They then tallied their calculations in a scrapbook, as if it was top-secret information.

One of young Buffett's most prized toys came from his Aunt Alice, who was quite fond of her peculiar but immensely likable nephew and made him an irresistible offer: If he would agree to eat his asparagus, she would give him a stopwatch. Buffett was mesmerized by this precise counting machine and used it in endless little-boy ventures, like marble races. He would summon his two sisters into the bathroom, fill the tub with water, and then direct them to drop their marble into one end. The one whose marble reached the drain stopper first was the winner (utilizing the tub's sloped shape). Buffett, stopwatch at the ready, timed and recorded each race.

But it was the second gift from Aunt Alice that sent six-year-old Buffett into a new direction—a fascination not with just numbers, but with money. On Christmas day, Buffett ripped open his present and strapped onto his belt what would become his most treasured possession—a nickel-coated money changer. He quickly found many ways to put it to good use. He set up a table outside his house and sold Chiclets to anyone who passed by. He went door-to-door selling packs of gum and soda pop. He would buy a six-pack of Coke at his grandfather's grocery store for 25 cents and sell the individual bottles for a nickel: 20 percent return on investment. He also sold, door-to-door, copies of the *Saturday Evening Post* and *Liberty* magazines. Each weekend he sold popcorn and peanuts at local football games. With him through all these enterprises was his money changer, taking in dollars and making change.⁸

What now sounds like an idyllic childhood took an abrupt turn when Buffett's father returned home one night to inform the family the bank where he worked had closed. His job was gone and their savings were lost. The Great Depression had finally made its way to Omaha. Buffett's